

good, and start using [Windows] + [F] when you need to do a file search!

Navigate to:

HCU\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Policies\Explorer

Set the DWORD NoFind (create it if it doesn't exist) to 1 to remove the "Search" item. A cleaner Start Menu!

Note: The above two hacks are best applied only if you're using the Classic Start Menu in Windows XP. You don't need the registry to clear these two items if you're using the XP Start Menu.

Killing 'Em Softly

XP is a lot more stable than 98, of course, but there's still a lot of scope for programs crashing. And then you need to bring up the task manager, arrange the processes by name, then end-task the non-responsive program. Automate this! Have non-responding programs shut down all by themselves...

Navigate to:

HCU\Control Panel\Desktop

Modify the String Value AutoEndTasks to 1.

This hack not only takes away the burden of ending tasks yourself, it can also help in cases where you can't delete a file because some process is using it—in *most* cases, this is a non-responding program. Windows will silently kill it.

Note that we said "most" cases; in some cases, you might wind up killing an application that is only temporarily unresponsive, as happens often when applications are performing particularly intensive calculations. To prevent this, you can instead set a lower threshold at which the system prompts you to manually end a hung task. The default is 5000 (milliseconds), meaning Windows